The Archive as Method

Multiple in Practice

I realise I'm the first here with a focus on modern and contemporary culture which highlights the role of an archive of the contemporary in defining what becomes "heritage". And what it means to intervene into what Susan Whitfield calls the "serendipity" of history.

Introduction

As you can see: "The archive as method". This is not so much a title but a proposition, or maybe a thought to keep in mind as I go through the presentation. Perhaps it's a way to complicate the things that we are expected to be. Complicate Asia, complicate art, complicate the archive by putting them in confrontation with one another. It is a method that we, at AAA, are always still working through.

Today, one hears the word archive used increasingly as a generic term, from online archives including newspaper to blog entries, to a variety of databases and actual online digitised archives. For many, the archive is no longer thought of in its conventional dusty basement stacked high with documents protected by a gatekeeper form. There does seem to be a widespread notion of, and an increasing interest in the widening potential of the archive. This has also been visible within the visual arts. AAA has participated in forums including Speak Memory a conference in Cairo in 2010 "exploring the rich array of methodologies that can be adopted to unearth, revisit or reactivate past artistic practices".[1] In Asia, we're in discussion with colleagues from the Indonesia Visual Art Archive and the Oral History Archives of Japanese Art, among others. And recently we've been consulted by individuals, organisations and state bodies interested in setting up art archives in Asia.

So what is it about the archive that is inciting people or organisations? What possibilities do the archive seem to promise?

Attempts have been made in the past to define the archive. This includes Michel Foucault's famous position that the archive is not only the traces left behind by history, but *is* history a priori. In other words the archive is not just a collection of texts that define a culture, nor even a set of institutions that preserve texts. The archive is 'the law of what can be said'. In my eyes, what is more exciting about the archive is that the archive is a system that can fundamentally alter and evolve. Its ontological structure continuously adapts and finds new forms with which to respond to its environment. Archival theorist John Ridener argues that these changes are based on three contexts: historiography, paradigm and technology, and I would add to that, localities.

[1] Speak Memory, Cairo, 2009, http://www.speakmemory.org/index.php?p=0

A recent shift in archival theory is the envisioning of an object's life beyond the structure of the archive. The archive has evolved into a multi-functional and inter-disciplinary situation, no longer fashioned as a space for accumulation, but as a platform and catalyst that enables the co-creation of meanings and experiences and where knowledge is envisioned as a latently inter-subjective process. This challenges Foucault's argument then. The archive is no longer a priori but is always in a state of flux. It becomes a catalyst of conversations. It does openness. In the age of the World Wide Web, when everybody is a producer and almost any kind of information is retrievable, how does that make us rethink ownership?

At AAA we believe that the solution is in the multiple. Multiplicity in provenance – in the case of an art archive like us, these are the narratives and records by the artist or the original archive owner; Multiple archivists, where the practice of archiving is a collective and collaborative project from researcher to annotator; and multiple to-the-point-of excess, of researchers, students, artists, curators, cultural workers, social historians, where the material and the records are interpreted, exhibited, written, debated, countered, enriched, and so and so forth, with the aim of socializing the material beyond AAA's immediate networks. These three layers form new networks and forms of association which are necessary for the effective redistribution of knowledge production.

Rather than try to define what an archive is or should look like, I propose to look at three models that are re-envisioning the archive as a method to challenge dominant narratives and positions of thought. Focussing predominantly on AAA, because it's the one I know best. I will outline the way in which the multiple is part of AAA's operating mechanism: from the team, the research and archiving process, to the dissemination of the records. I will end the presentation by casting light on the work of aaaarg.org and Southern Conceptualisms Network.

AAA

Let me first introduce you to AAA. We're a non-profit and non-governmental organisation based in Hong Kong dedicated to archiving and documenting recent developments in visual art in Asia. I encourage you to visit our physical space.

AAA was founded in 2000 by Claire Hsu and Johnson Chang. Claire, who remains the executive director today set up AAA in response to the urgent need to document and secure the multiple recent histories of contemporary art in the region, something almost unheard of at the time. The aim was also to counter-balance the forces of the art market in Asia. She set off with the vision of making information on contemporary art from Asia as accessible as possible for research.

Our first space opened to the public in 2003 with three bookshelves, and a modest office cum talks space. We out-grew it by 2007 when we moved to our current location, nearly triple the size with twice the library size, a specially designed climate controlled room for closed stacks, and spaces dedicated for programmes separate from the offices. Yet with 34,000 books on our shelves (not counting the hundreds of thousands of digitised primary source materials), a team of 34 local and overseas staff, and over 20 projects running at the same time, we are quickly out-growing this space as well.

There is a library team that deals with the delivering of the material that enters the organisation (by donation or purchase) into the public realm, both through the physical space and online. We have the research team that, with input from the library, director and myself develops the framework of the organisation and the scope of the collection. The programme team, which includes the public programmes and education department, works hand in hand with the research arm to develop cohesive programmes extending from our strands of research to generate dialogue, debate and ideas with audiences with varying degrees of specialisation.

The researchers are individuals based in cities across Asia who act as the eyes, ears and face of AAA on their ground locations. Their tasks include building up networks and collaborations, attending and documenting/photographing events and exhibitions, collating material and publications, and digitising primary source material as part of focussed research projects. This is all then sent to the Hong Kong office to be catalogued and re-disseminated. The research projects at AAA are predominantly researcher-driven. This means that AAA relies a great deal on the judgment of these individuals, and that, in accordance with the scope and framework delineated by AAA, develop archival research projects and work with us to better understand the context of their location and the role AAA can play. Today our research team is made up of 11 researchers across Asia – Hong Kong, China, Taiwan, Japan, Korea, the Philippines, India – and a head of research and programmes that strategises the cohesion and coordination of the various strands of research.

The collection strategy has over the last 4 to 5 years been readjusting from one primarily based on accumulation and large-picture-surveying – acquiring publications, framed mainly by geography, etc. – to one that prioritizes in-depth and denser pockets of thematic research, in digital format, to facilitate their access by external researchers. This strategy aims to highlight significant bodies of material that can act as entry points to inflect on related practices, ideas, conditions and people, as a way to unravel onto a wider constellation of activities.

This is guided by three main strategies: Pioneer organisations – looking at organisations that have played an important role in housing or facilitating the development of visual arts within their landscapes. Significant Individuals: we are simultaneously working on a number of individuals' archives. We recently completed the digitisation of eminent art critic and curator Geeta Kapur and her partner, artist Vivan Sundaram's, preserving 50 years' worth of documentation, bringing to light the names of over 140 artists, this archive records the shifting of paradigms both in India, and of India in relation to the world over a period of half a century. The third strategy is the Thematic, which includes our largest project to date on the 1980s in China bringing to light over 100,000 primary source documents and images largely from the archives of artists Mao Xuhui, Zhang Xiaogang, Wu Shanzhuan, Zhang Peili and curator Fei Dawei. This four-year research project led to the production of 75 hour-long interviews with active figures from the time which enriched and contextualised the material in China in the 80s. We are still in the midst of enriching the metadata for these records to enhance their access on the website. We are currently also working on a large scale performance art initiative, tracing the development of the medium in Asia, considering its rich regional history. One of the features of the initiative is Frog King's 1500 slides and photographs. Frog King is a pioneering performance artist from Hong Kong who has been practicing since the 1970s. His documentary photos and videos provide significant evidence of his work, as well as the art scenes in Hong Kong, Beijing and New York dating back to the 60s. He was also the representative of the Hong Kong pavilion in the last Venice Biennale. An important side note is that concerns around the reproduction and digitisation of performance art documentation, their authorship and copyright, are latent considerations in AAA's practice.

Let me also take this opportunity to clarify our actions vis a vis ownership. AAA's stand is that we do not insist on keeping the original material. Instead we believe in preservation through digitisation. This is also the medium that facilitates access and dissemination most efficiently and effectively. By reducing the power associated to ownership, the material object of cultural patrimony is liberated and can form new narrative associations.

AAA WEBSITE

Our biggest anxiety is for this material and its contents, which we've made great efforts to bring together, to stay, hidden, untouched, inactive, in our space. And a large part of our answer is in our website.

We launched AAA's new website in June. Our former website was useful as a bibliographic tool, but the records could be accessed from our physical space only. Acknowledging that very few people are

actually able to physically make it to AAA, this new platform, which took four years and an internal IT team to construct, brings AAA's collection into the public realm.

Now things can be viewed piece by piece – photographs, manuscripts, correspondences, slides. For instance you can browse, according to the proposed tree structure. The structure is not a standardised system, but each is developed in conversation with the donors of the original archive either to keep the original archive's integrity, or to suggest an alternative narrative legibility. With Geeta and Vivan's the structure is divided into four parts: Geeta's Essays and Lectures, her Curatorial work, Vivan as Organiser which is subdivided into organisations he co-founded, Kasauli Art Centre, likely the first artist-led international artist residency centre in India and SAHMAT another important early art space in South Asia, and Vivan's Artistic Career. By comparison, Zhang Xiaogang is today, one of China's most recognisable names but little is known of his career and practice prior to his rise to prominence on the global art market in the mid-2000s. It is therefore important that it his tree structure shows a chronology of his artistic practice from the 80s onwards.

Alternatively, the website and the collections can interact and cross-reference other parts of the website via the "search", including the recordings of our talks and symposia which are now viewable from our website, our rich database of relevant events around the world, the writings produced through our past newsletters and new journal Field Notes, as well as our physical library of 34,000 publications. All these are now inter-searchable across the site.

For instance if you search for the term "ink" you will call up the early paintings of Zhang Xiaogang, alongside the drawings of Vivan Sundaram and the collages of Roberto Chabet, displaying the rich and diverse contemporary experimentations of the medium through all three artists. Alternatively, if you type in "1980" you will find photographs documenting the exchanges of artists, architects, playwrights whose lives intersected via the Kasauli art centre in North India, founded by Vivan Sundaram, converging with the manuscripts of Hong Kong art critic Nigel Cameron who was active from 1970 to 2000, the experimentations of ink painter Wu Guangzhong, as well as the catalogues from a range of exhibitions in the 1980s from the Fukuoka Triennale – one of two art festivals dedicated to mapping the practice of Asian artists. And this is extremely exciting because it is this technology that enables a comparative perspective on spaces, times, people, practices, forms, concepts, etc. It allows us to see what kind of visual languages were active where, and which practices were being included in large scale exhibitions like the Fukuoka triennale, and which may have been more localised.

Let me also outline the back-end, the internal mechanism which enables the website to run. The same horizontal ideology is built into the mechanism of the internal structure as well. First at the level of the overseas researcher with the head office; previously the researcher would send physical hard

drives to Hong Kong office to be uploaded onto the back end. Information on the records were emailed on an excel sheet and manually typed in by the librarian. With the new system, the researcher, anywhere in the world can digitise and upload directly onto the back-end and can leave remarks, notes, details and annotations in pre-designed data fields – which they choose to make visible for the public or only for the librarian. This has created a dynamic environment of discussion and dialogue, where ideas or information can be exchanged immediately between the overseas researcher and the team in Hong Kong. As banal as this seems, the archive, conventionally, is a top-down, bureaucratic and legal exercise. The insertion of independent opinions and discussion into the practices of archiving minimises the possibility for dominant histories, a process of bureaucratic naturalisation, to overshadow alternative voices.

In a similar vein, we have also started to involve external annotators into the enrichment of data sets for each record. This function is also facilitated by the back-end system. This means that single or clustered records can be enriched by scholars and experts outside of AAA, from anywhere in the world. For instance Nora Taylor, Professor of South and Southeast Asian Art, at the School of the Art Institute of Chicago, and a longtime advisor of AAA, is currently helping us to contextualize the material of the defunct organisation Blue Space, in Ho Chi Minh City, active in the 1990s. In a state-controlled art environment where artists were watched and monitored closely, Blue Space was part of an era of mushrooming of arts organisations in Asia in the 90s. In South East Asia, they were safe havens for artists and cultural critics to gather, practice art and exchange ideas. Nora Taylor is working with AAA to annotate a cluster of records, identifying people and events, delineating the social, political and economic conditions of the time and describing the activities represented in the archival documents. In juxtaposing the perspectives of the annotators, here, Nora, AAA's researcher, Janet Chan and the donor of the archive, Tran Thi Huynh Nga, the founder and manager of the Center, we hope to present a choral of plural voices. These are also the necessary tools for comparative methodologies which we at AAA hope to enable for research, manifesting the complexity of contexts, conditions and practices that are present in Asia.

Thinking about words and vocabularies, we're in the early stages of a keywords project, which envisions the standardisation and implementation of a set of controlled vocabularies suitable for the navigation of our collection, generated out of the collection. Thinking of an image of an artwork by Lee Ufan or by Kim Taeho, rather than referring to it as "minimal", a concept grounded in the histories of European modernism associated with the essentialisation of form now largely adopted to describe any monochromatic or geometric works, can we formalise the application of original terms like Dansaekhwa for this specific painting practice, from Korea from 1970 to present? This will also help to attribute it to the distinct history and conceptual and critical aims out of which these practices transpired. It has been argued by critics and art historians that the primary concern of the process was

not one of form or colour but of the process of repetition, a spiritual search for neutrality and transcendence. Through keywords and terminology how can we help to make or question associations between Dansaekhwa and facets like “tradition”, “nation”, “contemporary” and possibly draw parallels with movements such as Monoha which was practiced in Japan during a similar time-period?

Reflectors

One last thing I want to mention about AAA is that we know we cannot do this alone. Which is why we are here today. There are too many stories still to be accounted for. One of AAA's visions is to develop a federated search. So that we can connect our collection with the collection at Indonesia Visual Art Archive, and with the two projects I will describe next. But for now, while we are still far from this end-goal, one of the ways we are trying to link up initiatives around the world is through our directories page. It is a technologically modest, yes, but rather than having a directory that acts as yellow pages of Asian – whatever that means – art or archival organizations, we're trying to connect to and map projects through shared conceptual interests: historiography, territorial concerns, memory-making, performance, etc. So that when you see AAA, you see that it is one participant, one node in a multitude of critical conversations and actions. And with this in mind, let me take a moment to look at the work of two projects which I believe are very much in line with AAA’s work.

Many of you in the room have probably come across aaaarg.org before. aaaarg.org is an online platform for the sharing of texts within the discipline of humanities: philosophy, art, activism, economics, cultural studies usually from a leftist position. Founder, Sean Dockray explains that “it has always been a positive project, an elaboration of love for the material being shared. It was a continuation of an already familiar type of activity: photocopying pages of books and giving books to friends so we could talk about it later or at least have a shared understanding.”[2] As friends, and friends of friends, started to use, copy, print, circulate the texts, an increasingly widening network of acquaintances, peers and colleagues also started to tap onto the forum and contribute their photocopies and thoughts. As one can imagine, this self-generation of texts, comes with the cumulated traces of its readers: folded pages, underlines, erasures, coffee spills, tears. And these are the imprints of subjectivities being formed, thoughts and arguments in the making, and these too become part of the repository of writings or markings in aaaarg.org whether one likes it or not. At the same time, discussion groups, tagging systems and reader generated categories start forming organically on the website. The website is now a tool for almost every humanities student out there, not only as a resource, but as a space where new ideas are generated, debated and shared, and new

[2] Sean Dockray, AAAARG.ORG DOES NOT EXIST, presented at Speak Memory, Cairo 2009, http://www.speakmemory.org/uploads/seandockray.pdf

online and offline communities based on ideas and shared interests are created and fed back into the archive. This is a poetic, human project.

Let me quickly also introduce the work of the Southern Conceptualisms Network, an archive network in Latin America whom I believe share many of AAA's visions. The initiative is set up in collaboration with Reina Sofia museum in Madrid, under the directorship of Manuel Borja Villel. Manuel's tactics, to overturn the hierarchical, bureaucratic and didactic position of the modern art museum, reimagining the museum not as owner but merely as a custodian of goods which belong to all. He imagines a universal archive, an archive of archives where opinions, commentaries and judgments are shared. Everyone can offer their own version of the story and can explain their perception of themselves, and of us. The universal archive, based on excess, enables a choral history to be constructed.[3]

Since 2007 the museum has been collaborating with the Southern Conceptualisms Network, a collective set out to safe-guard and recuperate archives and documentation of critical art of 1960s-80s in Latin America. Firstly, from being privatised by galleries, museums, private owners and universities and relocated to Europe and North America; secondly, to reactivate these practices by giving them agency to intervene into our present condition.[4] The activities of the Network started with a cartographies project, which identified and inventoried the state of the archives and documentation of 'critical art' dating from 1950 in South America. The team included 9 researchers from South America and accounted for 90 archives, institutional or individual, public or private. At the same time, they developed a chronology of key events in each country from the 1950s onward. These exercises highlighted the vulnerability of many of the archives and made visible the gaps where intervention was needed.

They then associate the archives with their local institutions - universities, libraries or arts organisation – to, together, develop proper preservation, digitization, and conservation policies with the final aim of opening up the archives for access by the public. This action is intended to empower the local communities by decentralizing the production of knowledge, and creating the conditions for micro-histories to be written. The ideas generated out of the archive continues to exist via the activities of the network: material from these archives are brought together and activated in the form of exhibitions, discussions, conferences, meetings, research. Their current exhibition, "Losing the Human Form", currently on show at Reina Sofia suggests the effects of violence on bodies and the experiments in freedom and transformation under the repressive order of the 1980s in Latin America.

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3 Manuel Borja Villel in his interview in The Museum Revisited, *Art Forum*, Summer 2010, XLVIII No 10

4 Miguel A Lopez, *Micropolitics of the Archive: Southern Conceptualisms Network and the potlicial possibilities of microhistories*, Field Notes, No. 2, http://www.aaa.org.hk/FieldNotes/Details/1208?lang=eng

And this brings together material and documentation of serigraphy, performance, video, poetic action, experimental theatre and participative architecture. Through these layers of experiences, the Southern Conceptualisms Network go beyond thinking of the material as historic evidence, but reactivate the critical potential for the movements and actions of artists and cultural critics of the 60s to intervene in the production of our present subjectivity.[5]

Conclusion

In conclusion, aaaarg.org, Southern Conceptualisms Network and AAA have built in the multiple and the subjective into their practice. Aaaarg.org as a community where information and knowledge are self-generated, to Southern Conceptualisms' where network is methodology. At AAA, the multiple is our operating structure.

Of course, there are still countless issues that we have yet to unknot: what is the value of the archive's socialization? Is there a difference between multiple and miscellaneous? How do we avoid falling back on the canonization of individual voices? But for now, if you ask me now, what is it in the archive that is inciting people or organisations? What possibilities does the archive seem to promise? We at AAA believe it is in its potential. The potential to re-envision and revise the way narratives and histories are told, the potential to reactivate, to give agency to the multiple, to dilute the dominant, to re-map and create new routes of intersections and movement of ideas, to challenge the meaning of ownership, and more importantly the potential to redefine how and by whom knowledge is produced.

Archiving is an act of creativity, imagination and experimentation, so long as we're archiving we keep envisioning. With this opening up of the archive, we are intervening into a past that is continuously being written. Because 'The past is never dead. It's not even past'. And this is the archive that we're creating today.

[5] Miguel A Lopez, *Micropolitics of the Archive: Southern Conceptualisms Network and the potlicial possibilities of microhistories*.